capabilities, support networks, and political intent. Though they were convinced that Pakistan was behind these attacks, the Afghan Taliban came to be viewed in a more nuanced manner. If anything, said Indian officials, the Afghan Taliban either denied launching anti-India attacks, or did so under tremendous Pakistani pressure.[54] Indeed, India was highly measured in its response to the 2008 and 2009 embassy bombings. In the first case, the MEA quickly responded that 'the attack on Indian Embassy was amongst the worst of the terrorist strikes in Afghanistan. Investigations of the Government of Afghanistan as also our own evidence that the attack was planned and executed by elements based in Pakistan make it a dangerous and unacceptable situation'.[55] Prasad confirms that India knew that it was not all Taliban that was the problem. 'In fact, those were days we [India] were not very worried about being attacked ... The attack came after Pakistan started viewing that India was getting better ratings as the most loved country in Afghanistan in 2007', he says.[56] Narayanan, who was generally averse to the Taliban regardless of where they came from, also admits that the Afghan Taliban did not directly attack India and most such attacks came from Pakistan.[57]

Though an unconvincing and logically weak explanation, some Indian officials believed that India's popularity among Afghans and excellent links with Karzai were the prime reason for Pakistan's strategic discomfort. Even after the 2009 embassy bombing, rather than blaming and criticising all Afghan Taliban factions, the MEA reported that the attack 'was carried out by elements from outside Afghanistan seeking to damage the excellent relations that exist between India and Afghanistan'.[58] Similarly, in 2010, despite the attack on the Hamid guesthouse in central Kabul that housed many Indian personnel, New Delhi refused to attack the Afghan Taliban (despite the Taliban having claimed responsibility for the attack).[59] Neither was the Afghan Taliban called obscurantist (like in the 1990s), nor were its members branded bigots. From within the Afghan Taliban umbrella, the Haqqani network came to be viewed as the primary threat. When asked whether he agreed with the popular narrative of the Afghan Taliban being a proxy outfit of Pakistan's security agencies, Menon categorically stated that 'Pakistan had unleashed hell. They attacked our [Indian] embassy in July 2008, over and over again. They had to use the Haqqani group to